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Study Courses

The following types of courses allow non-EU students to apply for a study visa or residence permit in Malta:

- Higher education programs including Undergraduate (Bachelor's), Postgraduate (Master's), and Doctoral (PhD) degrees.
- Diplomas and Foundation programs at MQF (Malta Qualifications Framework) Level 5 or higher.
- English Language courses provided by schools licensed by the ELT Council, typically for durations exceeding 90 days.
- Vocational training programs provided by recognized institutions such as MCAST (Malta College of Arts, Science and Technology) or the Institute of Tourism Studies (ITS).
- Credit-bearing short courses or exchange programs (Erasmus+) at recognized higher education institutions.

Embassy Appointment

Booking an appointment for a Maltese study visa is generally handled through the following channels:

- VFS Global: In most countries, Malta outsources visa collection to VFS Global. Students must create an account on the VFS Malta website specific to their country and book an appointment online.
- Central Visa Unit (CVU) Portal: In certain jurisdictions, appointments may be requested through official government booking portals.
- Direct Contact: If no external service provider (like VFS) is available in the student's country, they must contact the nearest Maltese Embassy or Consulate via email or telephone to request an appointment.

Applying for a Study Visa

The application process follows a specific sequence:

How to Apply

- Receive an official Letter of Acceptance from a licensed educational institution in Malta.
- Pay the required tuition fees and obtain a receipt.
- Gather all required documentation as per the checklist.

- Book an appointment at the designated Embassy, Consulate, or VFS Global center.
- Attend the appointment to submit documents, provide biometric data (fingerprints), and pay the visa fee.
- Attend a visa interview if requested by the consular officer.

Processing Time

- Standard processing time is usually between 15 to 30 days.
- During peak seasons (July–September), processing can extend to 45 days or longer.
- Students are advised to apply at least 8 to 12 weeks before their course start date.

Documents Needed

Before applying, students must prepare the following:

- Completed and signed National Visa Application Form.
- Valid passport with at least two blank pages, valid for at least three months after the intended stay.
- Two recent passport-sized photographs meeting Schengen specifications.
- Official Letter of Acceptance from the Maltese educational institution.
- Proof of payment for the course (receipt showing at least 50% or full payment).
- Proof of sufficient financial means (original bank statements for the last 3 to 6 months).
- Proof of accommodation in Malta (rental agreement, lease, or host declaration form).
- Travel medical insurance with a minimum coverage of €30,000 for the entire Schengen area.
- Flight itinerary or confirmed round-trip travel ticket.
- Copies of previous academic qualifications and transcripts.

Money requirements

Non-EU students must prove they have sufficient funds to cover their stay without working:

- The general requirement is 75% of the national minimum wage for each month of the stay.
- Correction: According to official guidance from Identita and the University of Malta, the financial requirement for the residence permit is a minimum of €950 per month of stay in Malta, excluding tuition fees. This figure is confirmed by the University of Malta's official visa guidance page (www.um.edu.mt) reflecting Identita requirements. The 75% of minimum wage formula is not cited in official sources

- Currently, this equates to approximately €18 to €25 per day if accommodation is already paid for.
- Correction: The per-day figure is not confirmed by official sources. The official minimum is €950 per month as cited above. (Source: University of Malta - www.um.edu.mt/international/students/visas/)
- If accommodation is not prepaid, students may need to show approximately €750 to €1,000 for every month of their planned residence.
- Correction: The official figure is €950 per month regardless of whether accommodation is prepaid or not, per University of Malta guidance reflecting Identita requirements. (Source: www.um.edu.mt/international/students/visas/)
- Funds must be shown through personal bank statements. If a sponsor is used, a notarized letter of sponsorship and the sponsor's bank statements are required.

Residence Permit

If the study program lasts longer than 90 days, the student must apply for an e-Residence Permit after arriving in Malta:

- The application must be submitted to Identita (formerly Identity Malta) in Msida.
- Correction: As of current Identita procedure, the residence permit application for students is submitted online through the Identita Expatriates Portal (expatriates.identita.gov.mt), not in person at the Msida office. Biometrics are collected in person at the Msida office only after the online application is submitted and an appointment is scheduled. (Source: identita.gov.mt/frequently-asked-questions/expatriates/non-eu-non-employment/study/)
- Students should apply within the first 90 days of their arrival.
- The student must present their passport, the visa they entered with, proof of enrollment, and proof of local health insurance.
- The applicant will have their biometrics taken again at the Identita offices.
- The residence permit is usually issued for one year or for the duration of the course if it is shorter

Working While Studying

Non-EU students are permitted to work in Malta under specific conditions:

- Students are eligible to work after they have been in Malta for 90 days on a valid study visa/permit.
- Correction: According to Identita (identita.gov.mt/central-visa-unit-student-visa-employment/), third-country nationals pursuing a full-time course leading to a higher education qualification recognised by MQRIC may take up employment for a maximum of 20 hours per week starting from their first year of study, upon issuance of the residence permit - not after 90 days of physical presence. The 90-day waiting period applies to students following courses that do not fall under Subsidiary Legislation 217.22. The blanket statement does not reflect the distinction between these two categories of students
- The maximum allowed working time is 20 hours per week.

- Students must maintain satisfactory attendance and academic progress to keep their work eligibility.
- The student must find an employer first; the employer then applies for an employment license through Jobsplus.
- Students cannot be self-employe

Renewing the Residence Permit

If the course of study lasts more than one year, the permit must be renewed annually:

- **Renewal applications should be submitted to Identita at least 8 to 10 weeks before the current permit expires.**
- **Correction: According to Identita (identita.gov.mt/central-visa-student-visa-extension-of-stay-in-malta/), for visa extensions students must contact the Identita Expatriates Unit not before 30 days and by not later than 21 days before the expiry of the visa. The 8 to 10 weeks timeframe stated above is not confirmed by official sources.**
- The student must provide proof of successful completion of the previous year's exams or modules.
- A new Letter of Enrollment for the upcoming academic year is required.
- Updated bank statements and health insurance must be provided.
- Evidence of continued accommodation in Malta is required.

Changing to a Work Permi

After graduation, students may transition to the labor market:

- Graduates of MQF Level 6 (Bachelor's) or higher can apply for a post-study stay-back permit.
- **This permit allows students to remain in Malta for 6 to 9 months to seek employment related to their field of study.**
- **Correction: According to Identita's official FAQ page (identita.gov.mt/frequently-asked-questions/expatriates/non-eu-non-employment/study/), the post-study permit is specifically 9 months in duration, applied for using Form CEA N.03. The range of 6 to 9 months is not confirmed by official sources; the official figure is 9 months.**
- Once a job offer is secured, the applicant must apply for a Single Permit (Work Permit).
- This application is processed by Identita and requires the employer to endorse the application.

Official Information

Official information regarding visas and residence permits can be found at:

- Identità (Agency responsible for residence permits): <https://identita.gov.mt/>
- Ministry for Foreign and European Affairs and Trade (Visa information): <https://foreign.gov.mt/>

- Jobsplus (Employment licenses and student work rules): <https://jobsplus.gov.mt/>
- Malta Further and Higher Education Authority (MFHEA): <https://mfhea.mt/>

Application Forms

Forms can be downloaded from the following official sources:

- Visa Application Forms: Available on the Ministry for Foreign Affairs website or the VFS Global Malta portal.
- Residence Permit Forms (Form CEA L for Study): Available on the Identità website under the "Expatriates" section.
- Student Work Permit Forms: Available on the Jobsplus website under the "Resources" or "Forms" section.

Tips for Students

To avoid common mistakes during the application process, students should consider the following:

- Source of Funds: One of the most common reasons for visa refusal is unclear origins of money. Ensure bank statements clearly show the source of income or savings.
- Document Translation: All documents not in English must be translated by a certified translator and often legalized or apostilled.
- Insurance Specifics: Ensure the health insurance policy specifically mentions coverage for "repatriation" and is valid for the entire Schengen area, not just Malta.
- Accommodation Proof: Avoid using temporary hotel bookings for the entire duration; a signed lease agreement or a formal "Declaration of Proof" from a host is much stronger.
- Attendance Records: When renewing a permit, poor attendance at school is a primary reason for renewal rejection.
- Early Application: Do not wait until the last minute. Maltese authorities require time to verify academic documents and financial records.

1. Study Courses

Non-EU/EEA nationals can apply for a Malta student visa for several types of courses, depending on duration and level:

- **Higher education courses (MQF level 5 and above)** — Bachelor's, Master's, doctoral, and other programmes at the University of Malta, MCAST, or MFHEA-licensed private institutions.
- **English language courses** — long-term courses at schools licensed by the ELT Council.
- **Vocational/technical courses (MQF levels 1-4)** — approved by the Malta Qualifications Recognition Information Centre (MQRIC).
- **Short courses (90 days or less)** — summer schools, short language courses, or short placements, which generally require only a Schengen short-stay (C) visa rather than a national visa.

The key distinction is course length: courses that exceed 90 calendar days require a National Long Stay Visa (D-Visa), while shorter courses fall under the short-stay Schengen visa rules.

2. Embassy Appointment

Long-stay (D-visa) applications for Malta are processed centrally by Identità's Central Visa Unit, but appointments are usually booked through an external partner rather than directly at an embassy:

- Identità's Central Visa Unit processes National (D) Visa applications through the VFS Global network, so most students book their appointment via the VFS Global Malta website for their country.
- To book: create an account on the relevant VFS Global Malta portal, log in, select the visa category (student/national visa), and choose an available appointment slot at the Visa Application Centre nearest to you.
- According to Identità's own student visa checklist, the application should be submitted at least 9 weeks before the course start date.
- In countries without a Maltese diplomatic mission or VFS centre, a "premium" remote process exists, where the applicant initiates contact by email with the Central Visa Unit and submits documents and their passport via courier.

3. Applying for a Study Visa in Malta

Documents needed (see Section 4 for full detail):

- Visa application form, passport, photo, school enrolment letter, proof of funds, insurance, accommodation proof, and flight itinerary.

How to apply:

1. Get accepted onto a course at an MFHEA-recognised institution and obtain an enrolment letter.
2. Gather the required supporting documents.
3. Book a VFS Global appointment in your country of residence.
4. Attend the appointment, submit documents and biometrics, and pay the applicable fee.
5. Wait for processing and visa decision.
6. Travel to Malta within the visa's validity window.
7. If the course lasts more than 90 days, apply for a residence permit in Malta within the first 90 days of arrival (see Section 6).

How long it takes:

- Via the standard VFS/extended process, processing typically takes around 4 weeks, within a process that overall takes 6 to 8 weeks.
- The premium (remote) process also typically takes around 6 to 8 weeks once the passport is received.
- Other estimates suggest the full visa process can take up to roughly 8 weeks from VFS submission, so applying early (well before the 9-week minimum) is strongly advised.

4. Documents Needed

According to Identita's official checklist for the Student National Visa (visas over 90 days), required documents include:

- Completed and signed visa application form
- Passport valid for at least 10 months
- One ICAO-standard passport photo
- VFS appointment confirmation
- School enrolment letter stating institution name, course name, MQF level, ECTS, duration, course hours, and holiday periods, with proof of tuition payment
- Bank statement (last 3 months) plus a recent bank certificate showing sufficient funds (see Section 5), or sponsor's bank statement, declaration letter, and ID copy if sponsored
- Copy of an international bank card to access funds in Malta

- Medical/travel insurance valid for the Schengen area with at least €30,000 coverage
- Flight itinerary to Malta (and return ticket, if the course is under 6 months)
- **Proof of accommodation for at least the first 14 nights**
- **Correction:** According to Identita's official Long-Stay Visa page (identita.gov.mt/central-visa-unit-national-visa-long-stay-visa/), the requirement is proof of accommodation to cover the first month of the intended duration of stay, not 14 nights.
- For minors: birth certificate, parents' passport copies, and signed parental consent
- All documents must be in English or translated by an approved translator.

5. Money Requirements

The financial requirement differs depending on the stage of the process:

- **For the visa application:** funds must amount to at least 75% of the national minimum wage for every month of study, shown via a 3-month bank statement and bank certificate.
- **For the residence permit (once in Malta):** the minimum funds required are 60% of Malta's annual national minimum wage or the poverty line, whichever is higher, for the applicant's household size, pro-rated for the duration of study.

Funds may come from the student's own account or a sponsor, provided the sponsor's bank statement, identification, and a signed declaration are included.

6. Residence Permit

After arriving in Malta, non-EU/EEA students on courses of at least one academic year/semester must apply for a residence permit (eResidence card):

- You must be physically in Malta to apply, since applications are handled in-country, not at embassies.
- Apply online via the Identità Expatriates Portal (expatriates.identita.gov.mt), creating an account and selecting the "Study – New" (CEA N.01) form.
- Upload scans of the required documents (passport, acceptance letter, proof of funds, insurance, accommodation), pay the fee online, and track the application status in the portal.
- Students must apply within the first 3 months (90 days) of their arrival in Malta; visa-exempt students must also apply within 90 days of entry.
- Once approved, you receive an eResidence card valid for one year of study, or until biometrics/interim receipt are completed.

7. Working While Studying

Yes, non-EU students can generally work part-time, subject to conditions:

- Students may take up employment in Malta for a maximum of 20 hours per week after their first three months of study.
- This applies to students on full-time higher education courses (MQF level 5+) recognised by MQRIC, as well as those on approved English-language or MQF level 1-4 courses, for a maximum period of 20 hours per week.
- Work is generally permitted full-time during official course holiday periods.
- A work authorisation/employment licence from Jobsplus is required in addition to the residence permit before starting work.
- Students must keep attending classes and maintain satisfactory academic progress; attendance below 75% of lessons can lead to Identità refusing to renew the visa.

8. Renewing the Residence Permit

If a course runs longer than one year, students must renew their residence permit annually:

- Renewal applications are submitted online through the Identità Expatriates Portal, generally before the current permit expires.
- Typical documents requested at renewal include: updated proof of academic progression/enrolment, updated proof of funds, valid insurance, proof of accommodation, and sometimes an updated police conduct certificate.
- Once approved, a new eResidence card is issued, valid for another year or until the expected end of studies, whichever comes first.
- It is advisable to start the renewal process well ahead of the expiry date, as incomplete documentation is a common cause of delay.

9. Changing to a Work Permit

Yes, students can transition from a study residence permit to a work-based permit after finishing their studies, though there is no fully automatic post-study visa:

- Malta offers a **9-month post-study residence permit** for eligible graduates, intended to give time to find employment or set up a business; if you leave Malta or the 9 months lapse, you do not get a second chance at this permit for the same or another course.
- During this period, or once a job offer is secured, the graduate (with the prospective employer) applies for a **Single Permit**, which combines work authorisation and residence into one renewable, typically one-year permit.
- High-skill positions may instead qualify under the **Key Employee Initiative (KEI)**, which offers faster processing.

- The student generally cannot work full-time until the Single Permit application is formally accepted by Identità, unless they already hold a temporary work authorisation.
- After several years of continuous legal residence and work (commonly cited as five years, with student-only time generally not counted), long-term residence status may become possible.

10. Official Information

Official Maltese government sources for study visas and residence permits include:

- **Identità (Central Visa Unit and Expatriates Unit):** <https://identita.gov.mt> — visa policies, residence permit FAQs, fees, and forms.
- **Identità Expatriates Portal:** <https://expatriates.identita.gov.mt> — online residence permit applications and renewals.
- **Malta's Diplomatic Missions / Visa FAQs:** <https://missions.foreign.gov.mt> — Schengen and national visa guidance by mission.
- **Jobsplus:** for student employment licences and work permit conditions.
- **MFHEA (Malta Further & Higher Education Authority):** for checking that an institution and course are officially recognised.
- **Servizz.gov.mt:** general government services portal, including visa and residence permit service pages.
- **VFS Global Malta:** for booking visa appointments by country.

11. Application Forms

- The **Long-Stay (D) Visa application form** and the **Student National Visa documents checklist** can be downloaded directly from the relevant Identità pages, for example via the "Courses exceeding 90 days" section under the Central Visa Unit's Student Visa pages.
- **Residence permit forms** (e.g., the Study application form, CEA N.01) are accessed and submitted through the Expatriates Portal at expatriates.identita.gov.mt once logged in, rather than as a standalone download.
- Some embassies/consulates and VFS Global centres also host a copy of the Schengen/national visa application form on their own websites.
- It is best to download forms directly from identita.gov.mt or the VFS Global Malta page for your country, since forms and checklists are periodically updated (the student visa checklist, for instance, was last revised in August 2025).

12. Tips for Students

Common mistakes and how to avoid them:

- **Applying too late:** Submitting less than 9 weeks before the course start date risks missing the intake. Apply as early as possible.
- **Incomplete or inconsistent documents:** Mismatched names, missing bank certificates, or insufficient proof of funds are frequent causes of delay or refusal. Use the official checklist and double-check every item.
- **Insufficient or wrong insurance coverage:** Insurance must meet the minimum €30,000 coverage and Schengen-wide validity; travel-only policies are often rejected.
- **Missing the 90-day residence permit deadline:** Many students forget that arriving in Malta does not end the process — the residence permit must be applied for within 90 days of arrival.
- **Working before authorisation:** Taking up employment before completing 90 days of study or before obtaining the required work authorisation can jeopardize the student's visa status.
- **Poor attendance:** Falling below the required attendance threshold can affect both course standing and visa/residence permit renewal.
- **Not budgeting for the full process:** Underestimating proof-of-funds requirements (75% of minimum wage per month for the visa stage) is a common reason for refusal.
- **Relying only on third-party blogs:** Requirements and fees change periodically; always cross-check details against identita.gov.mt before submitting an application.